

THE KEEPER OF GULL POINT

MARGARET ELLIS

Chapter I

IN WHICH THE LIGHTHOUSE KEEPER RECEIVES A LETTER

Mr. Tobias Wren had kept the light on Gull Point for nineteen years, and in all that time he had received exactly four letters. He said "exactly" whenever he told the story, as though the number were a matter of pride.

The fifth arrived on a Tuesday. It was addressed in a hand he did not know, sealed with green wax, and it smelled faintly of oranges. Tobias turned it over twice. He set it on the table. He made tea. He did not open it.

It's not that he was afraid of letters. He simply believed that a thing worth reading was worth waiting for, and that waiting improved most things -- tea, bread, and news among them.

By evening the wind had risen and the lamp needed tending. The letter stayed where it was, propped against the sugar tin, while the beam swung out over the water and back again, patient as a clock. Somewhere beyond the reef a ship was working north against the weather, and Tobias watched her lights until they slipped below the edge of the sea.

Chapter II

WHICH CONCERNS ORANGES, AND A VISITOR

The visitor came on Thursday, rowing a small grey boat with more determination than skill. She introduced herself as Miss Adeline Perch, and she wanted to know whether her letter had arrived.

"It has," said Tobias.

"And you have read it?"

"Not yet." He considered. "Waiting improves most things."

Miss Perch looked at him for a long moment, and then, to his surprise, she laughed.

Chapter III

IN WHICH THE LETTER IS OPENED AT LAST

They opened it together, at the table, with the sugar tin moved politely aside. Inside was a single sheet and a pressed orange blossom, and the sheet said only that the light on Gull Point had once guided a ship home, and that someone aboard had never forgotten it.

Tobias read it twice. Then he put the kettle on, because some news is best taken with tea.